Indo-Pacific Record Briefs

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Maritime Cooperation 2026: One Exercise, Two Official Accounts



Photo: 葛瀚强 / PLA Daily (via 81.cn). PLA Daily (解放军报) <http://www.81.cn/yw_208727/16483866.html> · Cited record 3924. Context, not evidence.

▶ Full photograph credit

Photo: 葛瀚强 / PLA Daily (via 81.cn). Image: PLA Daily (解放军报) <http://www.81.cn/yw_208727/16483866.html>, published with “China-Singapore "Maritime Cooperation-2026" Joint Exercise Opens” (cited record 3924). Context, not evidence.

Singapore places the exercise within wider naval relationships. Its closing account and China’s ministry emphasize bilateral trust, while their starting dates remain unresolved.

By **Benjamin Yang** Editor

Covers 3 September 2026 – 19 September 2026 China Desk and Singapore Desk 5 cited records

Analysis / Maritime Cooperation 2026: One Exercise, Two Official Accounts

> **The signal**

> Singapore places the exercise within wider naval relationships. Both ministries stress bilateral trust, while their different starting dates remain unresolved.

The development

Singapore MINDEF reported that RSS Steadfast and PLANS Dali participated in Exercise Maritime Cooperation at Zhanjiang on 5–9 September 2026. China's defense ministry described the same exercise on 14 September, giving a 3–9 September period. Both describe activities ashore and at sea.

Cites Singapore Desk · MINDEF Singapore — official releases, 2026-09-05 ;

Singapore Desk · MINDEF Singapore — official releases, 2026-09-09 ;

China Desk · MOD China (国防部), 2026-09-14

Opening note

Singapore's MINDEF places Maritime Cooperation 2026 at Zhanjiang on the final leg of RSS Steadfast's three-month deployment with several naval partners. China's defense ministry describes the exercise through bilateral cooperation. MINDEF's closing release uses that frame too: the wider deployment context and the shared message about trust sit alongside each other. [4466, 4472, 4164]

What stood out

MINDEF gives 5–9 September, with shore activity on 5–7 September and a sea phase on 8–9 September. China's ministry gives 3–9 September. PLA Daily reports a 5 September opening and preparatory meetings on 4

September; its later feature describes a five-day exercise ending on 9 September. Preparation and the formal exercise may have been counted differently, but no cited record explains the ministry's 3 September starting point. [4466, 4472, 4164, 3924, 4102]

Both ministries list communications, search and rescue, and casualty-related drills. MINDEF names gunnery firing; China's ministry names live-fire shooting. The Chinese ministry also lists replenishment, which neither cited MINDEF release names. PLA Daily describes replenishment positioning and line handling; it does not establish that fuel or stores were transferred. [4466, 4472, 4164, 4102]

Why it matters

For a policy reader, MINDEF's opening release places cooperation with China among Steadfast's engagements with several partners. Its closing release emphasizes the bilateral relationship, much as China's ministry does. Reading the closing statements alone would miss the deployment context. Reading the opening statements as opposing political messages would overstate the contrast: a deployment-wide release and an answer about one exercise have different scopes. [4466, 4472, 4164]

MINDEF's closing release cites improved operational competencies; China's ministry claims an increased ability to maintain regional peace and stability. These are participant assessments. The five records provide no independent performance measures against which to test them. [4472, 4164]

Routine baseline

MINDEF dates the series to 2015, and both ministries call this its fifth iteration. That supports an assessment of continuity. Without a comparable earlier program or scale, this brief makes no finding about expansion or improved combat effectiveness. [4466, 4472, 4164]

Term to know

sea riders

MINDEF uses this term for personnel exchanged between the participating ships during the exercise. China's ministry also reports that observers embarked on each other's vessels. Both accounts describe a professional exchange. [4466, 4472, 4164]

What I'm watching next

An official explanation of the 3 September starting date would clarify the exercise's broader timeline. More specific replenishment reporting could establish whether the work went beyond positioning and line handling. [4164, 3924, 4102]

A changed program or scale would become more meaningful alongside a documented earlier iteration. Comparable performance measures would help test the benefits the ministries assert. [4466, 4472, 4164]

▶ **Compare the official accounts**

Across desks

Each comparison cites a record from every desk it compares. A claim that institutions acted together names the record that says so; none is inferred from similar timing.

Compared side by side · China Desk and Singapore Desk

MINDEF gives 5–9 September; China's ministry gives 3–9 September. PLA Daily reports a 5 September opening, 4 September preparatory meetings and a five-day exercise ending on 9 September. The broader starting date remains unexplained.

Cites Singapore Desk · MINDEF Singapore — official releases, 2026-09-05 ; Singapore Desk · MINDEF Singapore — official releases, 2026-09-09 ; China Desk · MOD China (国防部), 2026-09-14 ; China Desk · PLA Daily (解放军报), 2026-09-06 ; China Desk · PLA Daily (解放军报), 2026-09-12

Compared side by side · China Desk and Singapore Desk

Both ministries list communications, search and rescue, and casualty-related drills. MINDEF names gunnery firing; China's ministry names live-fire shooting. China's ministry also names replenishment, which the two MINDEF releases do not name. This establishes a difference in their published lists.

Cites Singapore Desk · MINDEF Singapore — official releases, 2026-09-05 ; Singapore Desk · MINDEF Singapore — official releases, 2026-09-09 ; China Desk · MOD China (国防部), 2026-09-14

Compared side by side · China Desk and Singapore Desk

Both ministries call this the fifth iteration and associate it with cooperation and trust. This is an attributed assessment of an established exercise series; the records provide no comparative performance measures.

Cites Singapore Desk · MINDEF Singapore — official releases, 2026-09-05 ;

Singapore Desk · MINDEF Singapore — official releases, 2026-09-09 ;

China Desk · MOD China (国防部), 2026-09-14

Compared side by side · China Desk and Singapore Desk

MINDEF's opening release places the exercise within Steadfast's deployment involving several partners. Its closing release and China's ministry answer both emphasize bilateral trust and cooperation. The wider deployment context and bilateral message coexist in the Singapore account.

Cites Singapore Desk · MINDEF Singapore — official releases, 2026-09-05 ;

Singapore Desk · MINDEF Singapore — official releases, 2026-09-09 ;

China Desk · MOD China (国防部), 2026-09-14

▶ **Collection coverage and screening**

Coverage by desk

Counted per desk and never added together: desks differ in volume and in how far their records have been screened. Model-flagged counts analyzed records only.

Records each desk held in this brief's reporting window.

Desk	Records	Screening	Model-flagged	Days with records	Sources
China Desk	526	Analyzed: 257 Not selected for analysis: 265 Awaiting screening: 1 Analysis incomplete: 3	26	17	China Military Online (EN), Global Times — Defense, MOD China (国防部), PLA Daily (解放军报), Xinhua Military (新华军事) English, Simplified Chinese
Singapore Desk	18	Not selected for analysis: 7 Awaiting screening: 11	0	11	MINDEF Singapore — official releases English

Source trail 5 records

Every record this brief cites, grouped by the desk that collected it. English titles of non-English records are machine translations. Each record keeps its original title and source language; the original is authoritative.

China Desk

Machine-translated title

China-Singapore "Maritime Cooperation-2026" Joint Exercise Promotes Practical Cooperation Between the Two Sides

<http://www.mod.gov.cn/gfbw/xwfyr/yzxwfb/16486365.html>

中新“海上合作－2026”联演促进双方务实合作

MOD China (国防部) · 2026-09-14 · Simplified Chinese · Analyzed · Preserved record

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Machine-translated title

A Look Back at the China-Singapore "Maritime Cooperation-2026" Joint Exercise <http://www.81.cn/yw_208727/16485244.html>

中新“海上合作–2026”联合演习回眸

PLA Daily (解放军报) · 2026-09-12 · Simplified Chinese · Analyzed · Preserved record

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Machine-translated title

China-Singapore "Maritime Cooperation-2026" Joint Exercise Opens

<http://www.81.cn/yw_208727/16483866.html>

中新“海上合作–2026”联合演习开幕

PLA Daily (解放军报) · 2026-09-06 · Simplified Chinese · Analyzed · Preserved record

Singapore Desk

The Republic of Singapore Navy Successfully Concludes Exercise Maritime Cooperation with People's Liberation Army (Navy) <https://www.mindef.gov.sg/news-and-events/latest-releases/9sep26-nr/>

MINDEF Singapore — official releases · 2026-09-09 · English · Awaiting screening · Preserved record

The Republic of Singapore Navy and People's Liberation Army (Navy) Commence Bilateral Maritime Exercise <https://www.mindef.gov.sg/news-and-events/latest-releases/5sep26-nr2/>

MINDEF Singapore — official releases · 2026-09-05 · English · Awaiting screening · Preserved record

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← All analysis

Records held 5,097 Of those, analyzed 2,346

Run 166 in full

Official defense and security texts, preserved as published and analyzed in context.

Indo-Pacific Record is an independent research project created and edited by Benjamin Yang · ben.yang@gwmail.gwu.edu

Corrections and questions about any record are welcome at the same address.

Coverage is selective. Publication records what an institution said, not whether its claims are true or its capabilities exist.